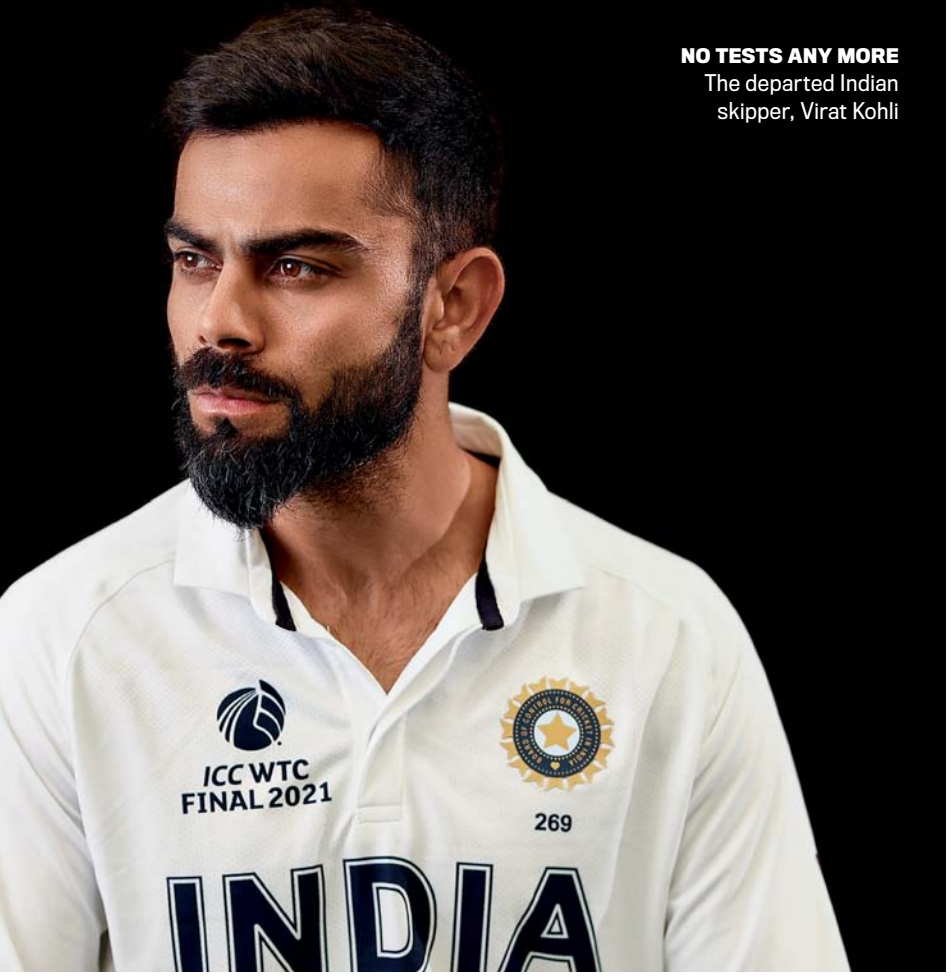


NO TESTS ANY MORE
The departed Indian skipper, Virat Kohli

GETTY IMAGES

54.82

Kohli's batting average across the three formats (Test, ODI and T20) of the game

#1

Kohli has the record for being the fastest to score 12,000 runs in ODI cricket—242 innings. He broke Tendulkar's record of 300 in December 2020

68

Tests played under Kohli's captaincy, over seven years. India won 40 and lost 17

2

Years since Kohli last scored a century. While India has never lost a Test series at home under Kohli's captaincy, it has never won an ICC trophy either

Source: espncricinfo

Kohli screamed into the stump mic. He would have felt embarrassed when some of the captain's teammates joined that chorus in a show of petulant defiance. I wouldn't be surprised if Dravid had something strong to say to his players about this behaviour once the team was back in the dressing room. This is not the way Dravid, the epitome of Test cricket's traditions, has played the game, nor would he want his team to be associated with such tantrums.

Indian cricket, one feels, is fortunate to have Dravid in the driver's seat at a time when its speeding train has been brought to a screeching halt. The team may have been thrown into disarray but they have a man in charge who could help skilfully navigate a difficult situation. He has experience and wisdom but also an innate respect for players. He has seen it all, having gone through a traumatic period during his tenure as captain when coach Greg Chappell was needling seniors in the team with his abrasive behaviour. After playing a major role in nurturing the Indian junior and A teams, he understands this new crop of players well. He knows how important it would be to keep Kohli content, especially since he still remains India's best batsman, someone who needs to quickly get back to his prolific run-scoring form.

A new captain has to be groomed and Rohit Sharma may not be a long-term answer, given his age and struggles in Test cricket. The middle order has to be rebuilt—Cheteshwar Pujara and Ajinkya Rahane seem to be chasing mirages instead of the red ball. Though India is a strong Test team, with a pace attack that could easily be among the best in the world, it needs a captain who can take Kohli's legacy forward.

INDIA IS LUCKY TO HAVE DRAVID AT A TIME THAT ITS INCREDIBLE MOMENTUM COULD HIT A SCREECHING HALT

Will K.L. Rahul, who has little experience, be the right man for the job? Or will the Indian selectors pay heed to Sunil Gavaskar's suggestion and catapult forward the mercurial and inexperienced Rishabh Pant? There are many questions that Dravid and the think-tank have to address. Fortunately, for them, most of the Test cricket this year will be played at home where India is almost impossible to beat.

The unpredictability of sport, especially cricket, is best reflected in the fact that just a month ago, this Indian team appeared almost invincible. A series defeat against a relatively weak South Africa, as also the manner of that loss, has all of a sudden brought to the surface a vulnerable side of the Indian team that no one imagined existed, at least not when Kohli was leading the side. ■

Pradeep Magazine *is author of* **Not Just Cricket: A Reporter's Journey through Modern India**